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The absurd as normal: why megaprojects are decadent

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Abstract

Purpose – The “fat tail” of megaproject failures recorded by Flyvbjerg (Flyvbjerg and Gardener, 2023) is a sign of decadence in megaprojects because it is indicative of the normal being treated as futile and absurd. Rival explanations for this normal absurdity have been advanced, including those of optimism bias, the planning fallacy, the hiding hand and strategic ambiguity. Each one of these is criticized for their lack of explanatory potential. A megaproject, it is argued, is essentially future-oriented to an open system future that cannot be controlled in all its particulars.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper is a theoretical exercise in constructive criticism of taken-for-granted assumptions in project studies. It draws on anthropology and the philosophy of science to do so.

Findings – The project management body of knowledge applied to megaprojects resembles a series of rituals whose latent function is to produce legitimation, despite it being constantly eroded by failure in practice. These provide accounts that rival project management theories can dispute. Standard research approaches in the field replicate these accounts of material and sociomaterial events that unsettle control of the variables of time, scope and cost. Rather than reproducing ritual, project studies might better attend to the institutional work that such accounts achieve, using anthropological and ethnographic approaches to understanding the ways in which these accounts function and with what existential effects.

Research limitations/implications – Rituals that do not serve their manifest function of control invite anthropological inquiry into their latent functions, which inquiry has been sketched here. Perhaps anthropological inquiry, as well as remedial managerial practices, might well prove to be connected?

Practical implications – Decadence is a “technical label” for language games in theory that mirror those played in practice in increasingly recursive loops. These merely provide available accounts that rationalize a failure to correspond to initial projections.

Social implications – Project studies of megaprojects are played out in language games in theory that mirror those played in practice in increasingly recursive loops. The language games should be accounted for in terms of rituals that do not serve their manifest function of control; instead, they invite anthropological inquiry into their latent functions. The social implications of this proposition are that it is anthropological interventions into megaproject cultures that might help dissolve the language games being played and better control the variables that they are played with.

Originality/value – The paper offers a novel perspective on project studies that is provocative and can be expected to create controversy.

Keywords Megaprojects, Ritual, Decadence, Open and closed systems, Events, Indexicality

Paper type Conceptual paper

All that is meant by decadence is “falling off”. It implies in those who live in such a time no loss of energy or moral sense. On the contrary, it is a very active time, full of deep concerns, but peculiarly restless, for it sees no clear lines of advance. The forms of art as life seem exhausted; the stages of development have been run through. Institutions function painfully. Repetition and frustration are the intolerable results. Boredom and fatigue are great historical forces.

It will be asked, how does the historian know when Decadence sets in? By the open confession of malaise . . . When people accept futility and the absurd as normal, the culture is decadent. The term is not a slur; it is a technical label. (Barzan, 2000, p. xvi).



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Introduction

The idea of absurdity as befitting the dramaturgy of everyday experience is hardly new. Barzan builds on the legacy of the existentialist thinker Camus (1942, 2013), whose assessment of the human situation as essentially absurd and devoid of purpose was epitomized by the myth of Sisyphus, forever rolling a boulder up a mountain. Barzan (2000) is interested in the normalization of futility, absurdity and acceptance of states of affairs. That one might describe major projects as futile and absurd might initially strike the reader as odd, but it ought not to. It is not that megaprojects themselves are futile and absurd, but that their project management is, if we define good project management as bringing projects in on time, budget and scope. There is good data to suggest that this is not often the case. Flyvbjerg (2003) writes that large-scale projects consistently experience cost overruns, delays and benefit shortfalls, despite repeated efforts to improve planning and management. If we are to judge an order as decadent, using historian Barzan's (2000) criteria, the acceptance of the futility of bringing major

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